TOPIC 01 · FUNDAMENTALS OF GOOGLE SHEET
LAB 1 THEME · GEMINI SIDE PANEL & SUMMARIES

Lab 1 — Open Gemini and Explore the Q3 Candidate Export

Maps to	LO1: open and use the Gemini side panel in Google Sheets to summarise a spreadsheet, ask questions about HR data across tabs and insert results, checking each answer against the data
Duration	25 minutes
Tools	Google Sheets · Gemini side panel (summary, prompts, sources, Insert) · OrchidBay_Q3_Applications_Export.xlsx
Mock data	data/OrchidBay_Q3_Applications_Export.xlsx
Course	Gemini for Google Sheet (C817) · v2.0
Prompts	https://tertiarycourses.github.io/C817-Gemini-for-Google-Sheet/prompts/#lab-1

Goal

Get to know Gemini in Google Sheets on a real recruitment export: summarise it, question it across two tabs, insert a result and spot what looks wrong.

What You Will Do

You are a talent analyst at Orchid Bay Talent Partners, a fictional Singapore recruitment and HR firm. The Q3 2026 hiring drive has just closed its first round: 243 rows exported from the applicant tracking system for eight client roles. You will open the Gemini side panel, read its automatic summary, ask questions in plain English, focus Gemini on the tabs you choose, insert a table into the sheet, and try the panel's controls - Retry, Undo, feedback and Clear history.

What You Will Build

OrchidBay_Q3_Applications_Export as a Google Sheets file with an inserted Applications_by_Position table, a check formula that confirms Gemini's stage count, and a filled Prompt_Log

Prerequisites

- A Google account with Gemini in Google Sheets: a Google Workspace plan with Gemini, or a Google AI Pro / Ultra plan. The Ask Gemini (spark) button must be visible at the top right of Sheets.
- Google Chrome or another current browser, signed in to that account.
- This lab folder downloaded, including data/OrchidBay_Q3_Applications_Export.xlsx.
- Data handling: all Orchid Bay data is fictional. With real candidate data, use only tools your organisation has approved, and only the columns the task needs.

Data note

Use only the supplied fictional Orchid Bay data or information you are authorised to process. Do not paste credentials, confidential business material or real candidates' or employees' personal data into Gemini, the AI function or a Gem unless your organisation has approved it.

Steps

Step 1. Download OrchidBay_Q3_Applications_Export.xlsx from this lab's data folder. In Google Drive choose New > File upload, open the uploaded file, then choose File > Save as Google Sheets - Gemini works best on a native Google Sheets file. Close the .xlsx tab and work only in the new Google Sheets copy. At the top right, click Ask Gemini (the spark icon) to open the Gemini side panel. Read the About_This_Data tab before you prompt.

PROMPT / CHECK — copy and adapt

```
Required state:
File : OrchidBay_Q3_Applications_Export (Google Sheets copy, not .xlsx)
Tabs : About_This_Data | Applications | Jobs | Prompt_Log
Gemini : side panel open on the right
```

Step 2. When the side panel opens on a sheet that has data, Gemini shows a short summary of the spreadsheet and some suggested prompts. Click View more to read all of it. You can summarise at any time with the shortcut Cmd + Ctrl + N (Mac) or Ctrl + Alt + N (Windows). Now ask in your own words. Gemini should say that one row is one candidate application, received between 2026-07-01 and 2026-09-26.

PROMPT / CHECK — copy and adapt

```
ASK GEMINI:
Summarize this spreadsheet. What does one row on the Applications tab represent, and what time
period does it cover?
```

Step 3. Ask Gemini to describe the columns, and compare its answer with the data dictionary on About_This_Data. It should report 243 rows of data and 16 columns. If a number is different, ask Gemini how it counted (for example, whether it included the header row).

PROMPT / CHECK — copy and adapt

```
ASK GEMINI:
Describe each column on the Applications tab in one line, and tell me how many rows of data
there are.
```

Step 4. Gemini can read every tab. To focus it, open the sources dropdown in the prompt box and tick only Applications and Jobs, then ask a question that needs both tabs. Before you insert the table, refine it with a follow-up. Data Analyst should show 41 applications for 2 openings. Click Insert, then rename the new tab Applications_by_Position. Insert keeps the result: the side-panel history is lost when you reload the page or go offline.

PROMPT / CHECK — copy and adapt

```
INSERT:
Using the Applications and Jobs tabs, make a table of each Position with the number of
applications and the number of Openings.

FOLLOW-UP:
Add a column Applications_per_Opening and sort the table from highest to lowest.
```

Step 5. Ask about the pipeline. Gemini should name Rejected as the largest stage (150 rows) and report 11 Hired. Then type the check formula into an empty cell on the Applications_by_Position tab - it must match Gemini's Rejected count. If it does not, the formula wins: ask Gemini how it counted.

PROMPT / CHECK — copy and adapt

```
ASK GEMINI:
How many candidates are at each Stage? Which stage has the most candidates?

CHECK:
Rejected count =COUNTIF(Applications!O2:O244,"Rejected")
Hired count =COUNTIF(Applications!O2:O244,"Hired")
```

Step 6. Explore the panel's controls. Send the first prompt, then click Retry for a different version. Use the thumbs up or down to give feedback. Open More options (three dots) to see More suggestions and Clear history, and Expand to make the panel larger. Then use Gemini for help with Sheets itself - you will use the answer about duplicates in Lab 3.

PROMPT / CHECK — copy and adapt

```
ASK GEMINI:
Explain this spreadsheet like I'm 5 years old.

ASK GEMINI:
How can I remove duplicates in Google Sheets?
```

Step 7. Finish by asking Gemini what looks wrong - do not fix anything yet. A good answer mentions several of: repeated Candidate_IDs, Source spelt more than one way (e.g. 'Linked In'), blank emails, salaries typed as text such as 'S$4,800', and a negative Years_Experience. Lab 2 checks each one.

PROMPT / CHECK — copy and adapt

```
ASK GEMINI:
Is there anything in the Applications tab that looks wrong or inconsistent? List the issues
with an example of each. Don't change anything.
```

Step 8. Prompt_Log already lists every prompt in this lab with its step. Ask Gemini to recap the conversation, copy each line into What Gemini did, add How I verified in your own words, and choose Keep, Revise or Undo in the Decision dropdown. Google Sheets saves automatically. Tip: the side-panel history is lost when you reload the page, so insert or copy anything you want to keep.

PROMPT / CHECK — copy and adapt

```
LOG:
List the prompts I sent you in this conversation. For each one, give a one-line summary of
what you did, so I can copy it into the Prompt_Log tab.
```

Sample Prompts

Use these prompts in the Gemini side panel in Google Sheets (or adapt them). Name the tab and columns, state the output, and always verify the result. The same prompts are in sample-prompts.txt in this lab folder.

Copy-ready prompts online: https://tertiarycourses.github.io/C817-Gemini-for-Google-Sheet/prompts/#lab-1

#	Purpose	Prompt
1	Summary	Give me a five-bullet summary of this candidate data for the Head of Talent.
2	Question	Which Source brought in the most applications?
3	Question	Which recruiter owns the most applications, and for which positions?
4	Help	How do I freeze the header row in Google Sheets?
5	Insight	What's interesting about this data? Give three observations with the numbers behind them.

Test It

Check	Expected result
Rows and columns	243 rows of data, 16 columns; dates 2026-07-01 to 2026-09-26.
Applications_by_Position tab	8 positions; Data Analyst 41 applications for 2 openings; sorted by Applications_per_Opening.
Stage check	Rejected = 150 and Hired = 11, matching Gemini's answer.
Issues spotted	Gemini lists repeated IDs, Source spelling variants, blank or invalid emails, text salaries and a negative Years_Experience.
Prompt_Log	Every prompt you ran has What Gemini did, How I verified and a Decision.

Checkpoint

Keep this file in Drive. Lab 2 opens its own copy of the same export, so you can start Lab 2 even if this lab is not finished.

Troubleshooting

If this happens	Fix
There is no Ask Gemini (spark) button.	Gemini needs an eligible Google Workspace or Google AI plan. Check you are signed in to the right account (profile picture, top right) and that your admin has turned Gemini on. Pair with a neighbour meanwhile.
Gemini says it can't help with this file.	You are probably in the .xlsx file. Choose File > Save as Google Sheets and work in the new copy.
Gemini's row count is off by one.	It may have counted the header row. Ask: 'Count only data rows, excluding the header.'
The side-panel conversation disappeared.	History is lost when you reload, close the file or go offline. Insert results you want to keep.
Gemini answers about the wrong tab.	Use the sources dropdown in the prompt box to select only the tabs you mean, and name the tab in the prompt.

Challenge

Ask Gemini which recruiter has the highest share of Rejected applications. Confirm it with two COUNTIFS formulas for that recruiter.

Reflection

Which of Gemini's answers would you have trusted without the COUNTIF check, and why is that risky?